

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 7

Byzantium

A Calm Journey Through Constantinople

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from 330 to 1453, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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Constantinople, between two shores

The city stood on a hilly headland at the southern end of the Bosphorus, with the sheltered Golden Horn to the north, the Sea of Marmara to the south, and Theodosius II's great land walls closing the west.



Surviving Byzantine sites plotted at their real locations on today's Istanbul. The coastline is modern; parts of the shore have since been filled in. The gold line marks the surviving Theodosian land walls.

Places you'll visit in the episode

Hagia Sophia: the church of Holy Wisdom, dedicated in December 537, under a dome more than 30 m across.

Hippodrome: the long racing ground beside the palace, home of the Blues and the Greens.

The Mese: the "middle street", lined with colonnades, running west through the great forums.

Valens Aqueduct: a surviving bridge of the water system that brought water from the hills of Thrace.

Chora: a small church restored by Theodore Metochites in the early 1300s, filled with mosaics and frescoes.

Basilica Cistern: Justinian's underground hall of more than 300 columns, where water rested for dry months.

Great Palace: a maze of halls, gardens and terraces running down from the Hippodrome to the sea.

Column of Constantine: purple porphyry in Constantine's forum, still standing, bound with iron rings.

Theodosian Walls: a moat, an outer wall and a tall inner wall, about six kilometres from sea to Horn.

Galata Tower: the tall stone tower of the Genoese walled town across the Golden Horn.

ELEVEN CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 330 to 1453



Long before, in about 660 BCE by ancient tradition, Greek settlers said to be from Megara founded a town called Byzantion on this headland.

324
Constantine the Great wins a decisive battle nearby, on the Asian shore, and chooses old Byzantion for a new capital.

11 May 330
The city is formally dedicated: *Nova Roma*, New Rome, soon called Constantinople.

Early 400s
The great land walls are raised under Theodosius II.

476
The last emperor in the west is set aside. In the east, the empire carries on.

527
Justinian becomes emperor, with the empress Theodora beside him.

January 532
The Nika riot. Fires spread and the old Hagia Sophia burns.

December 537
The new Hagia Sophia is dedicated, finished in less than six years.

541–542
Plague arrives from Egypt and reaches Constantinople in 542.

630s–640s
New Arab armies take Syria, Palestine and then Egypt.

c. 670s
"Liquid fire", later called Greek fire, appears; its recipe is still unknown.

717–718
A great siege fails; the walls hold through a bitter winter.

754 · 787 · 843
Iconoclasm: a council condemns holy images (754); Nicaea restores them (787); they are restored for good (843).

9th century
Cyril and Methodius of Thessalonica create a Slavic alphabet; Cyrillic grows from their work.

976–1025
Basil II rules, longer than any other Byzantine emperor.

c. 988
Vladimir of Kyiv sends warriors and accepts Christianity; the Varangian Guard grows from them.

1054
The date often given for the schism with Rome, though the parting was slow.

1071
Defeat at Manzikert; Romanos IV is captured, then released.

1081 · 1096–97
Alexios I Komnenos takes the throne; First Crusade armies arrive at the city.

April 1204
The Fourth Crusade sacks Constantinople; a Latin empire rules for nearly sixty years.

1261
The city is recovered; Michael VIII Palaiologos enters on foot.

Early 1300s
Theodore Metochites restores the Chora church with mosaics and frescoes.

1439
At the Council of Florence the churches agree a union, bitterly opposed at home.

29 May 1453
The city falls to Sultan Mehmed II, who makes it his capital.

An empire that rose and shrank



Approximate extent around 600 CE (after Justinian's reconquests in North Africa, Italy and southern Spain) and around 1000 CE, in the reign of Basil II. Frontiers moved often; borders are simplified. By Basil's death in 1025 the empire also took in the Bulgarian lands up to the Danube.

People you'll meet

Constantine the Great: chose old Byzantion as his new capital and dedicated it in 330.

Theodora: empress, clever and strong-willed, a real partner in power; died in 548.

Anthemius & Isidore: the two designers, learned in geometry, behind Hagia Sophia.

Cyril & Methodius: brothers from Thessalonica who devised an alphabet for the Slavs.

Anna Komnene: learned princess who wrote the *Alexiad* about her father, Alexios I.

Constantine XI Palaiologos: the last emperor, who died in the fighting in 1453.

Justinian I: emperor 527–565; laws, the new Hagia Sophia, and long wars in the west.

Procopius: Justinian's historian, and author of the bitter *Secret History*.

Photios: patriarch and scholar whose notes are the only trace of some lost books.

Basil II: reigned nearly fifty years and conquered the Bulgarian empire; died 1025.

Theodore Metochites: scholar and statesman who restored the Chora in the early 1300s.

Mehmed II: the young Ottoman sultan who took the city and made it his capital.

Legend or history?

Some of Byzantium's most famous stories rest on a single writer or on much later legend: Theodora's "royalty is a good burial shroud" (told only by Procopius), Justinian's boast that he had surpassed Solomon (written down long afterwards), Basil II's thousands of blinded prisoners (numbers probably exaggerated), and the marble emperor sleeping beneath the Golden Gate (Greek folk legend after 1453). The episode keeps these clearly apart from what the sources and the surviving buildings show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Learn more





Artistic impressions of the Basilica Cistern and of fishermen rowing home at dawn, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

Books

Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire ↗, Judith Herrin (2007; Princeton University Press).

The New Roman Empire: A History of Byzantium ↗, Anthony Kaldellis (Oxford University Press, 2023).

The Byzantines ↗, Averil Cameron (Blackwell, 2006).

Lost to the West: The Forgotten Byzantine Empire That Rescued Western Civilization ↗, Lars Brownworth (Crown, 2009).

The Fall of Constantinople 1453 ↗, Steven Runciman (Cambridge University Press, 1965).

The Alexiad ↗, Anna Komnene, trans. E. R. A. Sewter, revised by Peter Frankopan (Penguin Classics, 2009).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

Museums & places

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: the Joey and Toby Tanenbaum Gallery of Byzantium.

Byzantine and Christian Museum, Athens.

Dumbarton Oaks Museum, Washington, DC: the Byzantine Collection.

In Istanbul: Hagia Sophia, the Basilica Cistern and the Chora (Kariye), now a mosque, open to visitors outside prayer times.

Podcasts

The History of Byzantium, Robin Pierson: the empire from 476 to 1453, now complete.

12 Byzantine Rulers, Lars Brownworth: a short classic series of lectures.

"The Basilica Cistern at night, its columns standing in still water, a single drop falling and spreading in slow rings."

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